extended to 22 feet (6.74 metres). The learned Dr Peutinger recognised it for what it was: a medieval copy of a much earlier map of the world as it was known to the Romans. The town of Pompeii, destroyed in 79 CE, is shown on the map but so too is Constantinople, the former Byzantium, which had only acquired that name change in 330 CE, so the map is a compilation of information built up over several centuries. What became known as the *Tabula Peutingeriana* is essentially an overland route map, not intended to be geographically accurate but with lines drawn between cities, not to scale but in zig-zags, and the distances between them marked in Roman miles. The further it moves away from Rome the less accurate the map becomes (see illustration).

The last of *Tabula Peutingeriana*'s eleven sheets shows far Asia, with a great mountain range, 'Mons Imaeus' (the Himalayas), dividing China from India, and the rivers 'Ganges' and 'Indus' clearly but confusingly marked. A lesser mountain range in the bottom right-hand corner named as 'Mons Lymodus' has written under it in smaller letters *In hic locis elephanti nasciunter* ('In this place elephants are born'), which suggests that it represents the Western Ghats, which was famous elephant country. At the very bottom of the map is the misplaced island of Lanka, 'Insula Taprobane'. Only one major land route is shown extending into South India. It runs south from the head of the Persian Gulf and crosses the Western Ghats to emerge on the east coast between two rivers named as the 'Paleris' and 'Aunes', probably representing the Krishna and Cauvery. South of the latter are two regions named 'Patinae' and 'Comara' which we can link to Nagapattinam and Comorin. Below Comara the word PIRATE is written in bold letters in red.